

colleagues and his stockbroker. However, he remained optimistic as most of his wealth was invested in real estate. In fact, after seeing the stock market sink, Mr Talwar was completely convinced about the infallibility of the Indian Real Estate—after all, as his friend Mr Kalra put it, a house was a real asset bound to go up in value in a country with a housing shortage whereas stocks were only pieces of paper with no certain value. Mr Talwar swore never to invest in stocks and doubled down on real estate in the form of paying the next instalment for the flat he had booked in Empire Apartments.

However, soon the real estate engine too started sputtering. The first signs were the plateauing of house prices in 2013. Indian investors had seen property prices going up almost on a monthly basis and a continuous price appreciation was taken for granted. While the stagnation in prices upset Mr Talwar, he wasn't alarmed as yet as the press said that this was just a temporary demand slowdown. The real estate pundits (i.e. property developers and property brokers) who were featured on the financial news channels said that it was a matter of time before house prices picked up again.

Unfortunately, the slowdown in demand continued from 2013 to 2017 and prices continued correcting in some form or the other. The real estate developers started defaulting on loans from 2015 as they ran out of customers who would pay for their overpriced flats. Mr Talwar was now dealt with a double blow. The money that he had lent to the builders was stuck and so was the flat that he had booked in Empire Apartments. The flat, which was supposed to be delivered in three years, was now in its sixth year of construction and still a long way from completion. The builder had drawn down more than 95 per cent of the price of the flat and still did not have money to finish the project. Unfortunately, there were scores of such cases in Noida. Apart from a long court battle with the builder, which he was pursuing with his fellow house-buyers, there was nothing else that Mr Talwar could do. Thus, his dalliance with the stock market and real estate had ended in severe financial reverses even as the clock ticked down on his career.

He poured himself another peg and switched on the TV. A one-day international match that India had won against Pakistan five years ago was being telecast. But Mr Talwar's mind was somewhere else. He was fifty years